

# West Virginia - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

**Legend:** trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

## 1. 60-Second Briefing

### Initial conclusions

| Question             | Answer                                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| How good?            | <b>Lower-half Big 12 / bowl-fringe quality with a wide range; roughly a top-75 FBS baseline rather than a proven conference contender.</b> |
| Preseason consensus  | AP <b>unranked, zero votes</b> · SP+ <b>No. 72</b>                                                                                         |
| Returning production | <b>52% (No. 67) overall</b> · Off. <b>57% (No. 55)</b> · Def. <b>46% (No. 88)</b>                                                          |
| Primer power rating  | <b>-1.5</b> points vs. average FBS                                                                                                         |
| Expected season      | <b>4.9 wins</b> · most likely <b>5-7</b>                                                                                                   |
| Net vs. 2025         | ● ↔ <b>Similar overall, with a better offensive centerpiece but more defensive composition risk.</b>                                       |
| Confidence           | <b>Medium-low</b>                                                                                                                          |

**2026 identity:** West Virginia should try to stabilize the offense around RB Cam Cook, FB Kayden Luke and a run-capable QB room while the defense rebuilds around transfer additions such as EDGE Tobi Haastrup, LB Malachi Hood and S Andrew Powdrell. The defining tension is whether the new personnel can create competent QB/secondary play quickly enough to offset low defensive continuity.

**Bottom line:** The Mountaineers have a credible bowl path if RB Cam Cook gives the offense a dependable center of gravity and the QB competition resolves positively, but a defense replacing too many meaningful contributors leaves little margin for another inefficient offense.

**Beats expectations if:** QB Michael Hawkins Jr. or Max Brown gives the offense efficient QB play, RB Cam Cook translates his elite preseason recognition into Power Four production, and the transfer-heavy defense preserves 2025's better success-rate/havoc traits while cutting explosives.

**Disappoints if:** The QB competition remains performance-level unsettled, the rebuilt back seven cannot replace the volume of departures, and the offense repeats 2025's bottom-tier third-down/success-rate/explosiveness profile.

### Five things to remember

- 1 ? **QB question:** QB remains open: QB Michael Hawkins Jr. is a major candidate, but camp information did not declare him QB1 over Max Brown.
- 2 ★ **RB Cam Cook:** RB Cam Cook is the clear headline player: AP and Walter Camp second-team All-America plus Big 12 first-team recognition.
- 3 ? **Defensive availability:** Defense returns only 46% of production (No. 88) and loses multiple 2025 contributors through the NFL/CFL, eligibility and transfer routes.
- 4 ? **Defensive availability:** WVU lists no formal offensive coordinator; exact 2026 offensive and defensive game-day callers remain unresolved.
- 5 **Schedule pressure:** SP+ is No. 72 with 4.9 projected wins and SOS No. 44, so the bowl chase is likely to be decided in the Iowa State/Cincinnati/Kansas/Houston tier rather than against the schedule's top teams.

## 2. 2025 in Context

### Traditional Stats

| Measure         | 2025                                 | Assessment        |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Record          | 4-8 (2-7 Big 12)                     | ● Poor            |
| Scoring         | 21.8 PPG                             | ● Poor            |
| Total offense   | 349.5 YPG                            | ● Below average   |
| Rush offense    | 160.6 YPG · 3.7 YPC                  | ● Average / mixed |
| Pass efficiency | 6.93 YPA · 10 TD / 11 INT            | ● Poor            |
| Third downs     | 29.8%                                | ● Very poor       |
| Scoring defense | 30.8 PPG allowed                     | ● Poor            |
| Total defense   | 409.2 YPG allowed                    | ● Poor            |
| Rush defense    | 143.8 YPG · 3.6 YPC                  | ● Average / mixed |
| Pass defense    | 265.4 YPG · 8.17 YPA · 28 TD allowed | ● Very poor       |

The offense was poor almost everywhere except relative rushing competence. The defense also graded poorly by conventional totals, though rush defense was more respectable.

### Advanced Stats

| Measure                          | 2025             | Assessment             |
|----------------------------------|------------------|------------------------|
| Opp.-adjusted offense            | -3.69 · No. 99   | ● Below average        |
| Off. EPA/play                    | -0.080 · No. 102 | ● Below average        |
| Off. success rate                | 37.6% · No. 118  | ● Poor                 |
| Off. explosive-play rate         | 9.7% · No. 126   | ● Very poor            |
| Havoc allowed                    | 15.3% · No. 74   | ● Average / mixed      |
| Opp.-adjusted defense            | -2.95 · No. 95   | ● Below average        |
| Def. EPA/play allowed            | -0.027 · No. 53  | ● Average / mixed      |
| Def. success rate allowed        | 39.7% · No. 44   | ● Good / above average |
| Def. explosive-play rate allowed | 12.7% · No. 87   | ● Below average        |
| Havoc created                    | 16.5% · No. 49   | ● Good / above average |

**Advanced-stat read:** The offense remained poor after play-level and opponent adjustment, while the defense showed respectable success-rate and havoc results beneath bad totals. With only 46% defensive returning production, that efficiency is less likely to carry forward cleanly.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

## 3. Coaching

| Role             | 2026 status                       | Quick impact                                                                                                        |
|------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| HC               | <b>Rich Rodriguez</b> - returning | ● ↔ Program/system continuity helps, but WVU has no formal OC and the offensive game-day caller remains unresolved. |
| DC/LB            | <b>Zac Alley</b> - returning      | ● ↔ Continuity helps a heavily rebuilt defense, but the defensive game-day caller remains unresolved.               |
| OC / play-caller | <b>No formal OC listed</b>        | ● ↔ Exact offensive game-day caller remains unresolved                                                              |

## 4. Key Roster Movement

### Offense

| In                       | From               | Expected effect                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ◆ RB Cam Cook            | Jacksonville State | ● ↑ Strongest individual upgrade signal; national second-team All-America and Big 12 first-team recognition support a lead role. |
| ◆ QB Michael Hawkins Jr. | Oklahoma           | ● ↔ Legitimate QB1 candidate with athletic upside; starter remains undeclared.                                                   |
| ◆ WR DJ Epps             | Troy               | ● ↔ Paul Hornung-recognized receiving/return candidate without proven high-end Power Four production.                            |
| ◆ FB Kayden Luke         | Arizona            | ● ↑ Big 12 first-team recognition makes him a meaningful addition despite flexible usage.                                        |

| Out                     | To                                           | Loss                                                                                               |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| QB Nicco Marchiol       | Northwestern                                 | ● ↓ Removes experience from a room with no declared starter.                                       |
| RB Jahiem White         | North Texas                                  | ● ↓ Sixteen-start back departs; RB Cam Cook softens but does not erase the loss.                   |
| RB Diore Hubbard        | Wyoming                                      | ● ↓ 2025 rushing leader leaves, increasing dependence on RB Cam Cook.                              |
| WR Cam Vaughn           | Miami                                        | ● ↔ Material receiver departure, partly offset by WR DJ Epps and the broader incoming skill group. |
| WR Rodney Gallagher III | Arizona                                      | ● ↔ Another composition-significant receiver loss in an already reshaped offense.                  |
| RB Tye Edwards          | Transfer portal; destination not established | ● ↓ Portal departure; no destination is asserted.                                                  |

**Offensive net:** ● ↑ Heavily reshuffled but roughly similar overall; RB Cam Cook is the clearest upgrade, while unresolved QB/OL roles cap the positive call.

### Defense

| In                   | From     | Expected effect                                                   |
|----------------------|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ◆ EDGE Tobi Haastrup | Oregon   | ● ↔ Projected major edge role in an unsettled defensive two-deep. |
| ◆ LB Malachi Hood    | Illinois | ● ↔ Expected major role in a unit replacing veteran tacklers.     |
| ◆ S Andrew Powdrell  | UNLV     | ● ↔ Projects into a major role in a low-stability secondary.      |

| Out                  | To                                                  | Loss                                                                                             |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CB Michael Coats Jr. | Cleveland Browns                                    | ● ↓ Twelve-game starter leaves for an NFL roster, creating a clear experience loss.              |
| LB Chase Wilson      | New York Jets                                       | ● ↓ Material linebacker leaves on an NFL roster path.                                            |
| DL Edward Vesterinen | Winnipeg Blue Bombers - CFL Global Draft R1, pick 4 | ● ↓ Meaningful DL contributor leaves on a CFL draft path; signing is not asserted.               |
| S Fred Perry         | eligibility/graduation                              | ● ↓ Another twelve-game starter with 78 tackles and 10 TFL departs after eligibility/graduation. |
| LB Reid Carrico      | eligibility/graduation                              | ● ↓ 69 tackles and 4.5 sacks leave the linebacker room.                                          |
| DB Jordan Scruggs    | Maryland                                            | ● ↓ Later supplemental transfer to Maryland.                                                     |

**Defensive net:** ● ↓ Worse and less stable; incoming talent may keep it functional, but 46% returning production plus major losses create a substantial continuity tax.

## 5. How They Play

| Phase         | Identity                                                                                                                                   | What works                                                                                                    | Main vulnerability                                                                                                              |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Offense       | Build around the backfield and reduce obvious passing-down dependence while the QB competition resolves.                                   | RB Cam Cook is the best supported centerpiece; FB Kayden Luke and WR DJ Epps add role versatility around him. | QB certainty, final OL structure and the possibility of repeating 2025's terrible third-down/success-rate/explosiveness output. |
| Defense       | A transfer-heavy rebuild under returning DC Zac Alley that needs to preserve down-to-down efficiency/havoc while replacing veteran volume. | 2025 success-rate defense No.44 and havoc created No.49 show a useful disruption/efficiency foundation.       | Low returning production, major losses in the front seven/secondary and poor 2025 opponent-adjusted/explosive prevention.       |
| Special teams | Punter is the clearer position; placekicker remains open.                                                                                  | P Bryan Hansen carries Ray Guy watchlist recognition.                                                         | No authoritative placekicker winner was established.                                                                            |

## 6. Unit Grades

| Unit          | Grade | vs. 2025 | Confidence  | Why                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------|-------|----------|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| QB            | ● C   | ● ↔      | Low         | QB Michael Hawkins Jr. is credible, but no starter is declared and the room lacks a proven Power Four answer.                       |
| RB            | ● B+  | ● ↑      | Medium-high | RB Cam Cook brings the team's strongest national recognition and lead-role information, though multiple prior backs departed.       |
| WR            | ● C+  | ● ↔      | Medium-low  | WR DJ Epps has a major role, but material departures leave the room without a proven top-end receiver.                              |
| TE            | ● C   | ● ↔      | Low         | No high-confidence featured tight-end role is established; the unit remains under-proven.                                           |
| OL            | ● C+  | ● ↔      | Low         | OL Landen Livingston is a credible interior anchor, but the unsettled final five caps the grade.                                    |
| DL/Edge       | ● C+  | ● ↓      | Medium-low  | EDGE Tobi Haastrup brings upside, but major DL departures reduce proven continuity.                                                 |
| LB            | ● C+  | ● ↓      | Medium-low  | LB Malachi Hood is a major-role addition, but LB Chase Wilson, LB Reid Carrico and other linebackers leave meaningful 2025 volume.  |
| Secondary     | ● C   | ● ↓      | Low         | S Andrew Powdrell arrives, but CB Michael Coats Jr., S Fred Perry, DB Jordan Scruggs and DB Darrian Lewis leave.                    |
| Special teams | ● B-  | ● ↔      | Medium-low  | P Bryan Hansen is a Ray Guy watchlist punter candidate; kicker is still an open competition.                                        |
| Coaching      | ● B   | ● ↔      | Medium      | Rich Rodriguez and Zac Alley return, providing continuity, but no formal OC is listed and exact game-day callers remain unresolved. |
| Overall       | ● C+  | ● ↔      | Medium-low  | <b>SP+ No. 72 and 4.9 wins fit a functional below-average team with upside through RB Cam Cook and faster stabilization.</b>        |

## 7. Players to Know

**Recognition status:** preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

| Player              | Pos. | Evaluation                                           | Preseason recognition                                                                                                  | Why he matters                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------|------|------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ★ Cam Cook          | RB   | ● <b>Nationally recognized lead-back candidate</b>   | AP 2nd-team All-America · Walter Camp 2nd-team All-America · Big 12 1st team · Doak Walker · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY | The clearest proven/recognized centerpiece on the roster and the player most capable of raising a poor 2025 offense.                 |
| Michael Hawkins Jr. | QB   | ● <b>High-upside but unsettled starter candidate</b> | -                                                                                                                      | The team's ceiling changes materially if he wins the job and provides efficient dual-threat QB play; the starter remains unresolved. |
| Kayden Luke         | FB   | ● <b>High-end conference role player</b>             | Big 12 1st team                                                                                                        | Recognition plus major-role information makes him an important structural piece around Cook.                                         |

| Player            | Pos. | Evaluation                                           | Preseason recognition | Why he matters                                                                                    |
|-------------------|------|------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DJ Epps           | WR   | ● <b>Major-role receiving/return candidate</b>       | Paul Hornung          | He is the clearest recognized playmaking candidate in a reshaped receiver room.                   |
| Landen Livingston | OL   | ● <b>Interior anchor candidate</b>                   | Rimington             | One of the few high-confidence continuity pieces on an OL whose final five was still unsettled.   |
| Tobi Haastrup     | EDGE | ● <b>High-upside transfer / major-role candidate</b> | -                     | The defense needs newcomers like Haastrup to replace extensive front-seven turnover immediately.  |
| Malachi Hood      | LB   | ● <b>Projected major-role transfer</b>               | -                     | He enters a linebacker room replacing Chase Wilson, Reid Carrico and other material contributors. |
| Bryan Hansen      | P    | ● <b>Recognized specialist candidate</b>             | Ray Guy               | Punter is one of the more stable special-teams projections while placekicker remains open.        |

## 8. Schedule

| Item            | Assessment                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Overall         | <b>Moderate overall, but difficult for a negative-baseline team because most Big 12 opponents rate above WVU.</b>                                |
| Difficulty      | ● <b>6/10</b> · Moderate-hard · SP+ SOS <b>No. 44</b>                                                                                            |
| Hardest stretch | at TCU → at Texas Tech (after bye) → Kansas → Houston → at Utah                                                                                  |
| Swing games     | at Iowa State, Cincinnati, Kansas, Houston, Oklahoma State                                                                                       |
| Advantage       | Coastal Carolina and UT Martin open at home before the neutral Virginia game, giving the new QB/two-deep time to settle before the Big 12 grind. |
| Expected        | <b>4.9 wins</b> · most likely <b>5-7</b>                                                                                                         |
| Floor / ceiling | <b>3-9 / 7-5</b>                                                                                                                                 |

## 9. Betting Lens

| Angle           | Read                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Market posture  | Rich Rodriguez and RB Cam Cook can attract optimism despite SP+ No. 72; avoid paying for upside before QB and defensive replacement play stabilizes.                                         |
| Back them when  | As an underdog against teams that cannot force obvious passing downs and when RB Cam Cook can keep the offense on schedule; greater interest only after QB usage stabilizes.                 |
| Fade/pass when  | Asked to lay a meaningful number or face efficient passing offenses before the rebuilt secondary replaces CB Michael Coats Jr./S Fred Perry/DB Jordan Scruggs.                               |
| Key monitor     | QB winner/snap split, final OL five, defensive two-deep/secondary roles, exact game-day callers, placekicker winner                                                                          |
| Week 1 baseline | <b>West Virginia -15.0 vs. Coastal Carolina</b> · early rating-based fair value; compare with the live market before betting. <b>Live market: West Virginia -21.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).</b> |

## 10. Summary

West Virginia's clearest strength is RB Cam Cook, with FB Kayden Luke and WR DJ Epps adding useful structure around an unresolved QB competition. Defensively, EDGE Tobi Haastrup, LB Malachi Hood and S Andrew Powdrell enter a much less continuous group.

The bowl path is credible if the QB room stabilizes and Cook keeps the offense out of obvious passing downs. With only 46% defensive returning production, another inefficient offense would leave too little margin for five-plus wins.

## About this primer

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**Sources:** [2026 roster](#) · [coaches](#) · [fall camp depth chart](#) · [RB room](#) · [DB Jordan Scruggs](#) · [NFL roster check](#) · [NFL roster check](#) · [RB Tye Edwards](#)

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